The Gift and Train Platform: Munich to Dachau

By John Ciardi and Patricia Dobler

The Gift by John Ciardi

In 1945, when the keepers cried *kaput*
Josef Stein, poet, came out of Dachau
Like half a resurrection, his other half
eighty pounds still in their invisible grave.
Slowly then the mouth opened at first
a broth, and then a medication, and then
a diet, and all in time and the knitting mercies,
the showing bones were buried back in flesh,
and the miracle was finished. Josef Stein
man and poet, rose, walked, and could even
beget, and did, and later died of other causes
only partly traceable to his first death.
He noted - with some surprise at first -
that strangers could not tell he had died once.

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He returned to his post in the library, drank his beer,
published three poems in a French magazine,
and was very kind to the son who at last was his.
In the spent of one night he wrote three propositions:
That Hell is the denial of the ordinary. That nothing
lasts.
That clean white paper waiting under a pen
is the gift beyond history and hurt and heaven.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: John Ciardi
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INTRODUCTION

In the eyewitness account of William W. Quin of the 7th US Army: Dachau will stand for all time as one of history's most gruesome symbols of inhumanity. There our troops found sights, sounds and stenches beyond belief, cruelties so enormous as to be incomprehensible to the normal mind. Dachau and death were synonymous. John Ciardi in the previous poem The Gift and Patricia Dobler in the following: Train Platform: Munich to Dauchau pay tribute to the amazing people who survived the Holocaust.

Train Platform: Munich to Dachau By Patricia Dobler

1.

Two men, doubtless brothers, both huge
and with the same blank judicious face,
slump on a baggage cart. Near them
a decapitated deer, tied
to another cart. Sag of heavy meat,
blood stench, a pool of blood

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widening on the station floor. Pay
attention, hisses the mind, a lesson here.
And it's true, in Munich's Hauptbahnhof
death's uniforms rise quite naturally,
the oiled machine of metaphor
glides easily. It sickens me
how easily the images align: Aztec priest
in cape of human skin, Carthaginian children
rolled into fiery pits, and this commonplace scene:
just hunter's meat and dull round faces.

2.

Dachau is a village known
for its fine views and 18th c. chateau,
and a German on holiday inquires
of his dining companions, "Why
do these Americans visit the Camp?
What is it they hope to see?"

3.

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Early April, 1945; soon the war would be over. Some citizen
of Dachau, an amateur photographer, leaned from his balcony
early that morning. The sky was still gray; a slight drizzle fell. He
saw walking in the street below his rooms a scraggly line of
people. He got his camera, knelt behind his lace curtains (the
edges show in the pictures) and took three photographs. Three:
not one. Careful and deliberate, he recorded what he saw.

One: We see people walking; many are draped in blankets
or rags that look, from this distance, like prayer shawls. No faces.

Two: We see a group of fifteen prisoners and, to one side,
an armed guard. All the prisoners are stooped; one is

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humped,
as if he carries a burden on his back, under the blanket which
drapes him. The street is slick with rain; the figures are reflected
in the street.

Three: We see many more people and we also glimpse the
balcony from which the photograph was taken. A fine house is
in the background—smoke puffs from the chimney, there are
carved gables and windows. We see women in this group of
prisoners. Some of them wear high-heeled shoes; their legs look
white and bare.

4.

What do we hope to see? Carmelite nuns
live near the site of Barracks 26,

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where the priests and ministers were stacked.
I think the sisters hope to see nothing;
they contemplate how blood and the empty mind
desire to converge and with their prayers
they refuse that coupling.
After the war the poets said,
"No poems about the camps," and
they were right, but still I hope
if not for an image, perhaps
for a small composition to place
against the blank-eyed brothers
back on the platform in Munich. I hope
to see again the young couple from Bremen
who struggled with their infant in his stroller,
rolling it over the difficult white stones
which cover the acres of Dachau. They pushed
the stroller from Jewish shrine to Catholic shrine,
then they stopped at the Carmelites' door.
They heard chants rising and falling, they saw
bright scraps of cloth fluttering from trees
in the courtyard. "What does this mean?"

4NG Fanatics

they asked each other, not being Catholic
or Jewish, but merely German,
young, and of a mind to understand.

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